what the West has regarded as Hindu fatalism, and to which V. S. Naipaul referred as a tendency for 'non-doing'.

And yet this is a very partial understanding of Hinduism. The *Bhagavad Gita* asks Hindus to raise themselves by the self; that is, to use whatever elements Fate has dealt them—the circumstances of their birth, their location, their access to wealth, the opportunities for education and so on—as best they can to move towards self-realisation. The fact that circumstances are what they are does not deny the Hindu the freedom of will to seek to change them. The position of the planets at the time of a Hindu's birth may have determined some of his or her possibilities, charting good phases and bad ones in their lives, but then it is up to them to make what they can of them. It is wrong to suggest that everything is willed by Fate for the quiescent Hindu, that his destiny is decreed. The Hindu works with God to fulfil his potential. God is not just above and beyond us; to the Hindu, He is also within us. He struggles with us, suffers with us, strives with us. To that degree, the Hindu knows he shapes his own fate, in partnership with God.

Early in my United Nations career, my first boss, a lay preacher in his native Denmark, asked me a pointed question: 'Why should a Hindu be good?' Not, I replied, in order to go to heaven or avoid hell; most Hindus do not believe in the existence of either. If heaven is a place where a soul should sprout white wings and sing the praises of God, it must be rather a boring place, hardly worth aspiring to, and God must be a rather insecure Being. And as for hell, the very notion of hell is incompatible with Hindu cosmology, since it suggests there is a place where God is not, and that, to the Hindu, is impossible to conceive, for God is everywhere or He would not be God.

If Hinduism is, indeed, a *manava dharma*, an ethical code applicable to the whole of humanity, then it is legitimate for a non-Hindu to ask: why indeed should a Hindu be good? First, because he is bound by the moral obligation to fulfil his *dharma*, the right action his religion enjoins upon him always to undertake.

The Hindu is taught that there are six principal obstacles to the performance of *dharma*: two are Purusharthas gone wrong, *kama* as lust rather than desire, and *lobha* as greed and avarice for material